

Chicago Tribune



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TUESDAY, MAY 27, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Plan draws pushback from polluters

Johnson-backed proposal would put additional requirements on new industrial developments

By **Brian J. Rogal**
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson will push forward this spring an ordinance designed to reform land-use policies that environmentalists say for decades led to pollution in Black and Latino communities. Some advocates for heavy industry are worried. None deny

minority neighborhoods on the South and West sides suffer more from the dirty air, water and soil that historically came from steel mills, smokestacks and truck traffic. But they say if Johnson's proposal puts more obstacles in the way of new industrial businesses getting started, it could squelch much-needed job creation. "We need to make sure we're not

disincentivizing industry, because these jobs are needed throughout the city," said Jonathan Snyder, executive director of North Branch Works, a nonprofit advocate for economic development along the North Branch of the Chicago River. "If we send a signal that coming here is an expensive, complicated process, we will not be successful in attracting business." Called the Hazel Johnson Cumulative Impacts Ordinance, a tribute to the late Far South Side environmental and community

activist, the proposed law was introduced at the April 16 City Council meeting and referred to the rules committee. If passed by the full City Council, it would establish a community-based environmental justice advisory board and require industrial companies seeking new development permits to conduct community health assessments, ensuring their projects would not further damage public health. Supporters of the ordinance point out it will have no impact on

businesses that don't have significant environmental footprints, including new restaurants, retail and other commercial development. And developers with proposals for new heavy industry are already required to conduct air quality assessments and traffic studies, so community health assessments should not be much of an additional burden. "If it passes, it would be an important example of a local

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ILLINOIS LEGISLATURE

Continuing education credits are latest perk

Lawmakers who are lawyers get them for simply going to work

By **Ray Long**
Chicago Tribune

State legislators who are also lawyers in Illinois are getting a new perk, courtesy of the state Supreme Court. They just need to show up for work in the Illinois General Assembly and they'll be able to collect credit toward satisfying continuing education classes required to keep their law licenses in good standing. The new benefit came about from a little-noticed change in Supreme Court rules, a move encouraged and endorsed by multiple lawmakers. It took effect Jan. 1, just in time for the ongoing spring legislative session. At least 29 lawmakers were notified that they could qualify for up to 12 of the 30 educational credits they need to collect over two years. The lawmaker-lawyers can chalk up three hours of credit by simply attending one day of a legislative session, a committee meeting or a subcommittee hearing, according to the new rule. One catch is that they can collect only three credits throughout a legislative session, such as a spring session that lasts several months or a fall veto session that lasts a few weeks, court officials said. While many current lawmakers — notably House Speaker Emanuel "Chris" Welch, Senate President Don Harmon and Senate Minority Leader John Curran, all three of whom are lawyers — not surprisingly support the new benefit, some former legislators and state legal experts said the benefit for a select few of the state's nearly 86,000 active lawyers raises questions about why members of the General Assembly get the special break. They and others also said it smacked of favoritism from a Supreme Court whose budget relies on lawmakers' approval.

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Pha'Tal Perkins, center, founder of Think Outside Da Block, speaks with Chicago police Officer John McBroom about logistics in the parking lot of the Ogden Park Fieldhouse on May 13 as Perkins does a walk-through for the upcoming event "Roll N Peace." **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Layoffs leave violence outreach group reeling

After years on front lines, Englewood team faces losses as DOJ shifts priorities

By **Nell Salzman**
Chicago Tribune

For a city with hundreds of shootings each year, the work that Pha'Tal Perkins does with kids in Chicago is quiet but significant. Perkins, 41, remembers that after a bullet went through a window and into the neck of an 11-year-old girl last year in the West Englewood neighborhood, for example, he spent long hours bringing food and making sure her mother and 16-year-old brother felt safe leaving the house. He talked through her treat-

ment with them as she recovered, and as the girl's brother had been out of school, he helped him reenroll. Perkins coaches his team of outreach workers to take similar approaches with other families in crisis. "(We) once (were) a part of that street lifestyle," he said. "But because (we) show them love and care, they respond with respect." His team of workers does round-the-clock work to tackle the root causes of community violence, leading peer-to-peer support and group therapy sessions. They help kids apply for college and jobs, and

host programming for kids. They are often the first to crime scenes, even before police. In late April, due to the end of a federal grant that supported many of those efforts, Perkins had to lay off five of the outreach staff at his violence intervention nonprofit, Think Outside Da Block. His organization isn't the only one that received cuts, and he said there will be half the number of people this summer out in the community mediating conflicts. Gutting that infrastructure could have a ripple effect, Perkins said, as Chicago law enforcement

relies on groups like his to keep the city safer. The impact, according to Perkins, could mean fewer conflicts resolved and more shootings. **'Retraumatizing'** On April 22, Metropolitan Peace Initiatives, a nonprofit organization in Chicago that supports Perkins' nonprofit along with several others, received an email from the U.S. Department of Justice that one of its federal

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Brightest minds struggle to find work

Job openings in research and development are plunging as the Trump administration ramps up funding cuts to government agencies, private contractors and universities. Scientific research and development job postings are down 18% since Trump took office. **Business**

New aid system begins in Gaza

The U.S.-backed Gaza Humanitarian Foundation took over the handling of aid despite objections from the United Nations. Desperately needed supplies started flowing on a day that saw Israeli strikes kill at least 52 people in Gaza. **Nation & World**



ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A solemn salute

Cmdr. Roy Taylor, of American Legion Post 800, salutes at the McKinley Park Memorial Day parade ceremony on Monday. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Sacrifice of fallen soldiers honored at Arlington

Memorial Day sees Trump laud troops, his political efforts

By **Seung Min Kim**
Associated Press

ARLINGTON, Va. — President Donald Trump paid tribute to fallen service members during a Memorial Day ceremony at Arlington National Cemetery on Monday, in an address that honored the "great, great warriors" yet also briefly veered into politics as he boasted of a nation he is "fixing after a long and hard four years." Though the holiday is one that U.S. presidents typically treat

with pure solemnity, Trump began it with an all-caps Memorial Day social media post that attacked his predecessor and called federal judges who have blocked his deportation initiatives "monsters who want our country to go to hell." Yet at Arlington National Cemetery, where more than 400,000 have been laid to rest, Trump commemorated the sacrifice of U.S. service members and singled out several Gold Star families to tell the stories of their fallen relatives. "We just revere their incredible legacy," Trump said. "We salute them in their eternal and

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